Best Tech Forward

Daisy Chittilapilly, *50*
President, Cisco India & SAARC

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Leading Cisco's tech revolution in the country

ON HER FIRST DAY IN A NEW school in Thiruvananthapuram, Daisy Chitillapilly recalls how her father put her—all of six years—on a school-bus. When they reached the school, the conductor left her with a single piece of instruction. "Just follow these three girls." She did. To her utter surprise, they walked out of the school, across a wide, busy road. She could barely keep them in sight and was nearly in tears. Soon, they reached another gate, and, Daisy recalls, "I see my father, all 6 feet 1 inch of him, standing there. He had put me on the bus but also ensured I followed the trail." This kind of upbringing is what Daisy, who now heads Cisco's operations in India & Saarc, believes built an independent streak in her.

As a Class 12 student, she fancied a career in teaching but wrote the engineering entrance exam 'out of respect' for Sr Freida at Holy Angels, who suggested she give it a try, being a school topper. Daisy cracked it, going on to do a B.Tech. in electrical and electronics engineering at the College of Engineering, Thiruvananthapuram. In 1995, aged 22, she got placed in Wipro in Pune. After two years in tech sales, she joined Cisco in 1997 in Bengaluru.

Daisy took over as head of Cisco India in August 2021 at a time when the Covid pandemic had unleashed a massive flux. "It shaped me as a leader," she says. "When you assume leadership with a lot of ambiguity around you, you also hone your ability to make decisions without every piece of data and certainty."

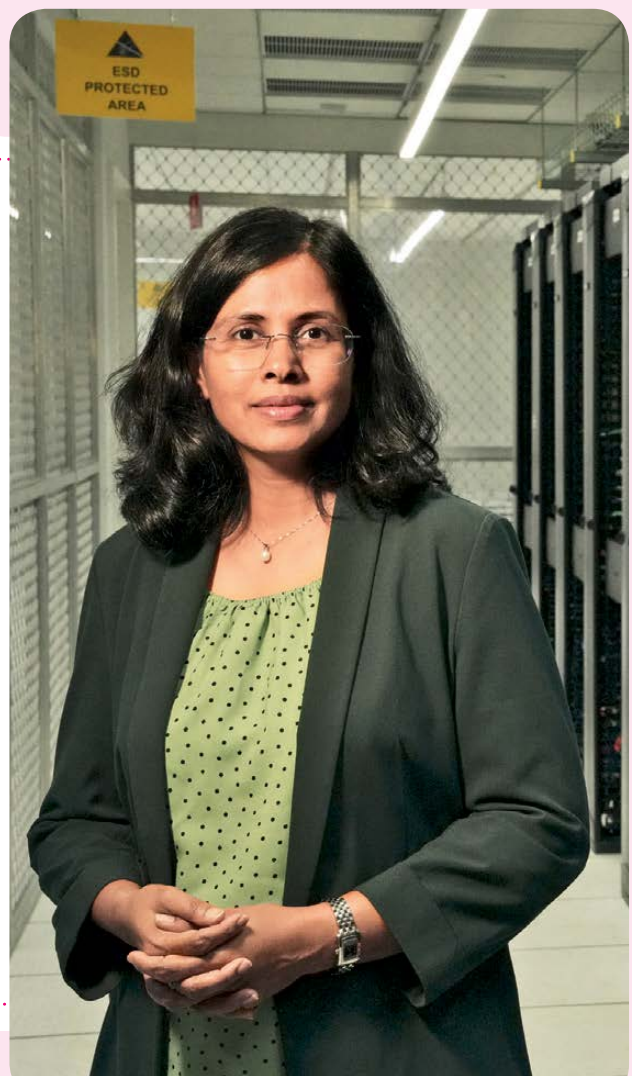
Covid also upped the use of technology in health, manufacturing and agriculture in India. "That means India will not just be one of the world's fastest growing large economies, but tech spending too will be one of the fastest growing. If you are in tech, this is a market where there is no dearth of opportunities," says Daisy. ■

–Ajay Sukumaran

ROLE MODELS

"Early in my career at Wipro, my superboss was a woman, so was the domestic business head. They were the role models I think I followed unconsciously"

TRAVEL BUG **Daisy tries to make time for two trips a year, one within the country and one outside. She has just come back two weeks ago from a trip to Antarctica, where lucky weather allowed them to cross the Drake Passage. She has visited all seven continents, including a wonderful four-day Inca trek in Peru**



SELVAPRAKASH L